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9594805

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1. Executive Summary

This report will investigate Tourism in Poland. It describes Poland as a destination, including its location, development and appeal. For this, a destination analysis is done through SWOT, PEST and TALC Analysis.

The report highlights a description of tourism attractions, visitor types and even what motivates them to travel to Poland.

Moreover, a current economic value assessment is considered, including its contributing to Poland' GDP, trends in the market and even investments and developments that have been done through the last years in the country.

Finally, the report comprises an explanation of the social and cultural effects that impact in Poland and where the destination lies in the Irritex Model.

2. Introduction

Poland is a large and attractive country with various cultural, historical and environmental resources that are contributing to an increasingly tourism growing market. UK visitor numbers to Poland grew significantly in the last years due to the easily accessibility in direct flights. Travellers are benefiting from the low prices and the advantageous geographic location (ABTA 2019).

This report evaluates Poland as a case of study on its tourism development, location, appeal, visitor types and tourist attractions. Furthermore, a value economic analysis is done along with an investigation on the social and cultural impacts that can arise in the destination.

3. Background and Appeal of Poland

Poland is a Central Europe country and it is located in the North European Plain. It is one of the largest countries of Europe and it has an irregularly shape. Poland is northerly bordered by the Baltic Sea, north eastly by Russia and Lithuania, eastly by Belarus and Ukraine, southerly by Slovakia and Czech Republic and westly by Germany (European Union 2019).

It is a country with a huge historical, cultural and natural wealth that is being conserved through the years. The main tourist areas are in the southern and northern borders (Boniface, Cooper and Cooper 2016: 439).

The Baltic Coast is one of the most popular destinations, offering sandy beaches and lagoons along with the coast. In Southern Poland, winter sports, mountains, and spas are the key attractions, with prepared facilities and amazing landscapes (Boniface, Cooper and Cooper 2016: 440).

Although Warsaw is the capital of Poland, Krakow is the city that attracts more visitors. Following these two, Wroclaw, Gdansk, Lodz, Szczecin, Poznan and Lublin are the ones that receive more tourists (ABTA 2018) as highlighted in Table 1.

Table 1. Inbound Arrivals by City 2014-2019 (Euromonitor International 2019)

'000 trips	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
Gdansk	505.7	375.6	504.0	792.1	742.5	758.5
Krakow	2,500.0	2,520.0	2,650.0	2,800.0	2,850.0	2,910.0
Lublin	271.5	275.6	255.5	249.7	262.2	272.3
Poznan	310.6	287.5	342.0	349.5	360.2	373.1
Szczecin	435.3	401.1	410.7	422.2	440.1	455.5
Warsaw	2,550.0	2,650.0	2,733.0	2,630.0	2,732.0	2,827.0
Wroclaw	658.9	694.2	1,030.0	1,050.0	1,063.2	1,075.5

In these historic cities prevails the iconic architecture buildings, medieval castles, churches and ancient views. Moreover, Torun, Zamosc and Krakow are selected as World Heritage Sites (Boniface, Cooper and Cooper 2016: 439).

4. Destination Analysis

4.1. SWOT

Poland is usually known for a cultural and historical destination, for the relaxing beaches in the coast or the adventure in the ski resorts by the mountains (Fedykovych 2018). It is considered to be a safe country, privileged with a great location within Europe.

The country has its strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats j analysed in Table 2.

Table 2. SWOT Analysis adapted from Euromonitor International (2019)

Strengths	•Geographic location •EU grants •Economic and social improvements •Cultural and historical heritage •14 World Heritage Sites •Entertainment attractions developments •Safety - low risk of terrorism attacks or natural disasters
Weaknesses	•Polish Government's low prioritisation of Tourism •Poor condition of roads and airports infrastructures
Opportunities	•Increasing number of air tranportations routes •Investments in marketing and promotion
Threats	•Seasonality •Unpredictable weather •Lack of qualified labor

Although Tourism in Poland is highly increasing, the Polish Government does not take it as a priority, and so, the promotion and marketing that it is been done is not sufficiently effective (Euromonitor International 2019). There is a need to improve and develop tourism support infrastructures and resources like streets, airports and entertainment.

For Poland to become a wealthy country it must take advantages of the investments that have being present such as the increasing number of air transportation routes around Europe and even other countries in America and Asia. Even though Tourism is a growing sector, the country must be ready to possibly face some challenges.

4.2. Tourism Area Life Cycle

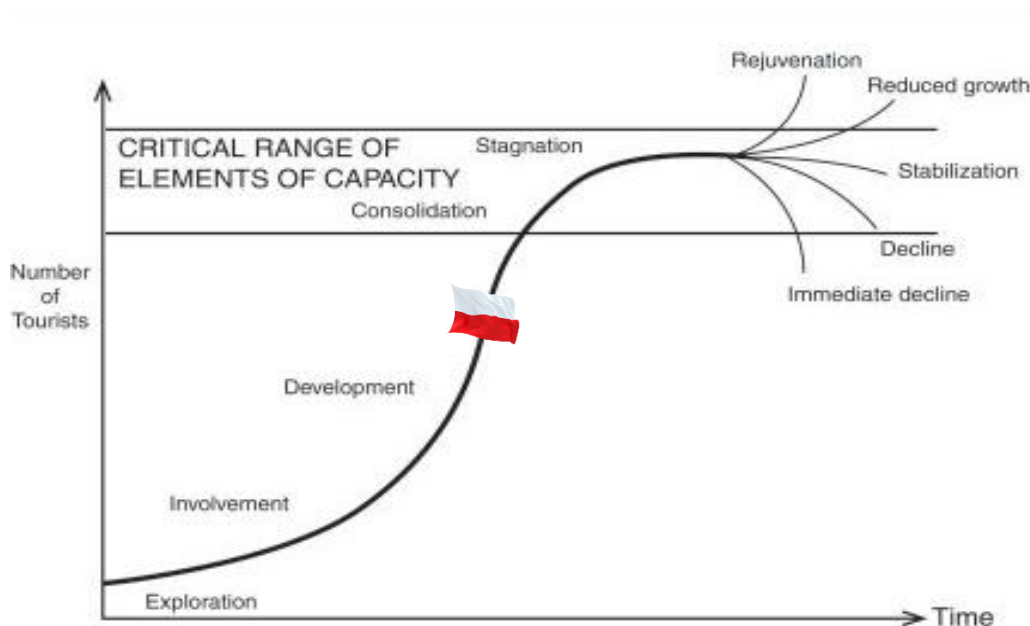


Figure 1. Tourism Area Life Cycle (Butler 1980)

Even though inbound and domestic tourism numbers are rising, and it is being now a key contribution to its GDP, Poland remains to be between the Development and Consolidation stages, exactly as marked in Figure 1 with a Polish flag.

This analysis is since there are quite developed cities just like the main ones, Krakow and Warsaw, that are providing to be a huge key contribution to the Tourism Industry in Poland. However, there are others that have not reached their consolidation (Boniface, Cooper and Cooper 2016: 81).

4.3. PEST

Table 3 analyses the political, economic, social and technological structure points of Poland.

Table 3. PEST Analysis adapted by MarketLine (2018)

Political

- Political and bureaucratic corrupt system
- Transition to Democracy
- Tense relation with the EU

Economic

- Resilient economy
- Emerging investment destination
- Improving employment conditions
- Tourism sector is economically increasing

Social

- Highly education population
- Sustainable and inclusive growth
- Low spending on healthcare

Technological

- Improved marketing and promotion in Tourism
- Weak performance on innovation

5. Type of Attractions

A tourist attraction is considered, to be any site that sufficiently encourages people to travel to some place to visit it. Most of these attractions depend on its physical or natural character. However, some cities have been altered because of the tourism expansion and, so, purpose-built structures are created to rise the appeal of tourists (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 16). According to Swarbrooke (2002) tourist attractions can be classified in the following categories, specified in Table 4:

Table 4. Tourist Attractions Categories (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 267)

Natural Environment

Purpose-Built

- Sites created with other intentions than attracting visitors
- Sites created specifically to attract tourists

Special Events

- Temporary- Occasionally in different places and times
- Permanent- Regularly in the same place and time

Poland owns a well-established range of attractions with seaside, countryside and mountain features (BMI Research 2016).

Considering natural environment attractions, Poland preserves unique and varied natural landscapes within its 23 national parks and environmental appeals. Some of them are the Wieliczka Salt Mine in Krakow, the Morskie Oko Lake in Tatra Mountains and Bialowieza Forest, classified as World Heritage Site and Special Area of Conservation (TripAdvisor 2020).

In relation to purpose-built attractions, the Wawel Royal Castle and Auschwitz-Birkenau Concentration camps were not built purposely to attract tourists, but now-a-days are two of most sites that are attracting them. Moreover, there are purpose-built attractions that were constructed precisely to capture the attention of tourists, for example, the MOCAR Museum of Contemporary Art in Krakow and the Museum of the Second World War in Gdansk (Lonely Planet 2020).

Poland is investing in various events, such as Open'er Music Festival, which happens every year and the UEFA European Championship that was just temporary.

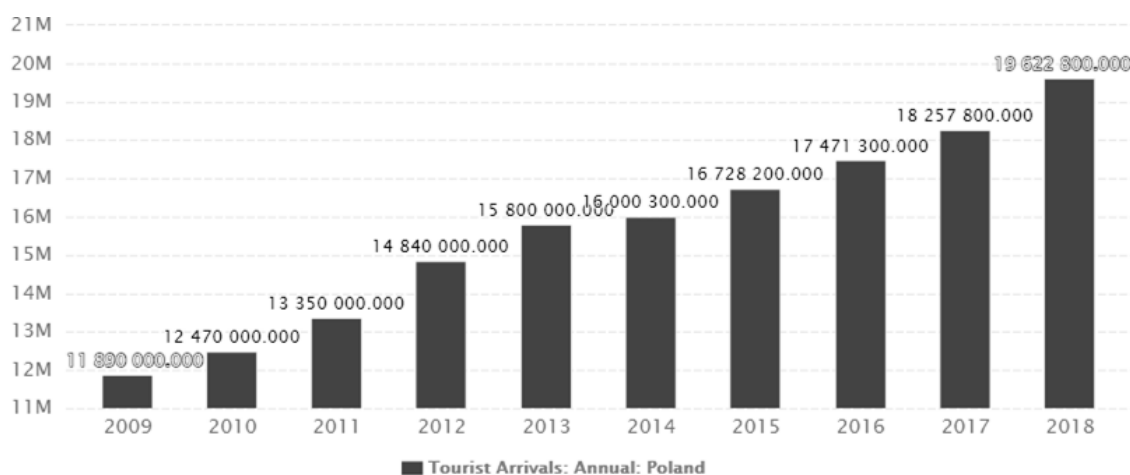
6. Visitor Types and Motivations

6.1. Inbound Tourism

Tourism in Poland has never had much influence on the economy of the country. It is growing since the 1990's and aims to predict further investment and growth within the sector (Boniface, Cooper and Cooper 2016: 438).

Throughout the last 10 years Polish Tourism has been increasing, reaching 85.9 million foreigners. As Graphic 1 displays, these include 19.6 million international tourists in 2018, 7.5% more than in the previous year, and 66.3 million same-day visitors (Statistic Poland 2018).

Graphic 1. Poland International Tourists Arrivals 2009-2018 (CEIC Data 2018)



The number of inbound arrivals has been influenced by the expansion of air routes to and from Poland. PLL LOT, Wizz Air and Ryanair launched new connections to vary cities in America and Europe (Euromonitor International 2019).

In the case of foreign tourists, their main motivations to travel are to visit family and friends, leisure, holidays and business circumstances. In perspective of same-day visitors, they came mainly for shopping and recreation (Statistics Poland 2018).

As stated by Euromonitor International (2019) in Table 5, inbound visitors can be classified mostly as groups, families and couples relating to their leisure trips.

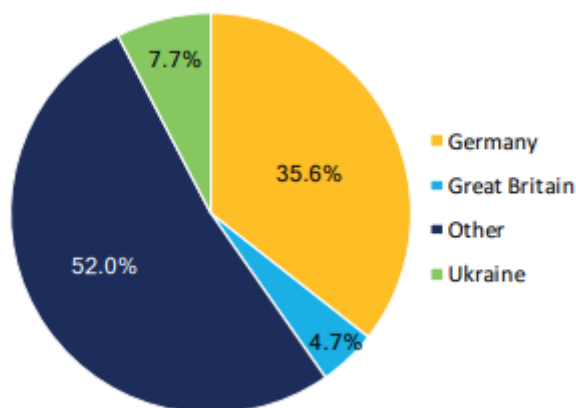
Table 5. Leisure Inbound Demographics: Number of Trips 2014-2019 (Euromonitor International 2019)

'000 trips	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
Couples	2,474.8	2,484.7	2,552.6	2,759.7	2,846.7	2,910.6
Families	3,520.7	3,521.9	3,799.7	3,995.4	4,071.8	4,192.4
Groups	4,809.7	4,742.7	5,118.6	5,222.9	5,193.7	5,281.5
Singles	1,794.1	1,798.3	1,712.4	1,633.9	1,568.3	1,614.6
Other	124.7	116.5	111.7	118.1	125.1	164.3
Total	12,724.0	12,664.0	13,295.0	13,730.0	13,805.7	14,163.4

Relating this type of incoming demographics, the consideration is that Poland receives mainly organized mass tourism or individual mass tourists, being their focus of interest the cultural and heritage tourism (Fletcher et al 2013).

According to Statistics Poland Website, German, Ukrainian and British nations play a leading role in the Polish Tourism Market, as Graphic 2 verifies. However, Russia, USA and Asia countries such as India, China and Japan tourists' numbers are increasing (Euromonitor International 2019).

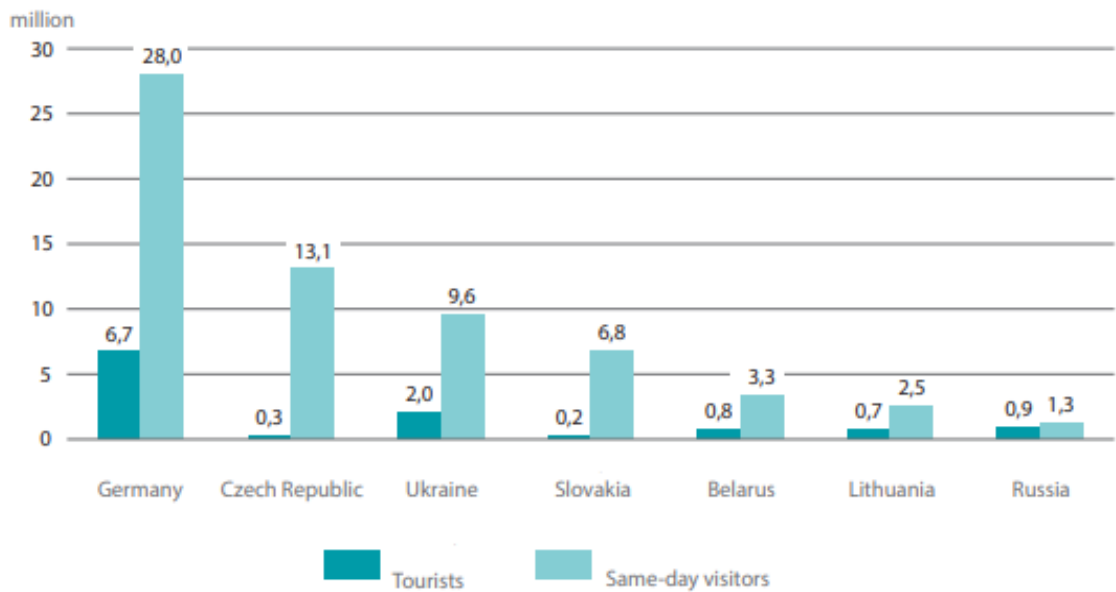
Graphic 2. Nationality of Foreign Visitors to Poland (Horwath HTL 2019)



Proving with Graphic 3, Poland neighbouring countries take a major part of the country same-day visitors, contributing with PLN 26 billion, equivalent to more than £5 billion.

However, international tourists are the ones who spend more money related to their stay in Poland with PLN 34.95 billion in expenses, corresponding to almost £7 billion (Ministry of Sport and Tourism of Republic of Poland 2018).

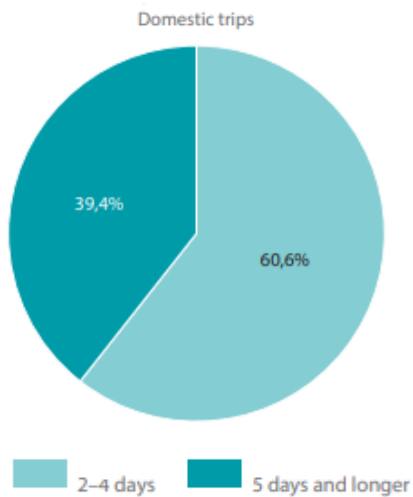
Graphic 3. Neighbouring Countries Visiting Poland (Statistics Poland 2018)



6.2. Domestic Tourism

Domestic trips are also increasing due to Poles better incomes along with developments in the infrastructures. In 2018, 47.736 thousand inhabitants of Poland travelled within their country, an increase of 3.9% comparing to 2017 (Statistics Poland 2018).

Graphic 4. Poles' Length of Stay in Domestic Tourism (Statistics Poland 2018)



As demonstrated in Graphic 4, domestic short-term trips (2 to 4 days), matches with 60.6% of the total Domestic Tourism in Poland, around 28.934 thousand trips. Moreover, long-term travels (5 days and longer), represents 39.4%, about 18.800 thousand. Both had an increase since 2017. The amount of expenses incurred in relation to domestic trips of Polish residents was PLN 27.7 billion, the same as £5.48 billion (Ministry of Sport and Tourism of Republic of Poland 2018).

Their main motivations to travel are to visit family and friends, leisure, recreation and holidays.

7. Economy

Poland's tourism industry is becoming more increasingly recognized and established.

After the UEFA Championship was hosted by Poland in 2012, the numbers of tourists boosted, and the destination turned more popular to visitors from different countries. As an EU member, Poland is receiving numerous grants that are used to improve economic and social affairs of the country (BMI Research 2016).

Regardless of the contribution that Tourism has in Poland GDP, the sector is influenced by other beneficial impacts. According to the Official Website of the Ministry of Sport and Tourism of the Republic of Poland (2018), Tourism Industry has 5.9% of contribution in Poland GDP. Although it isn't a huge contribution, the trend will be upward, and if a drop in the tourist's number and expenditure happens the economy of the country will be affected.

The expansion of tourism in Poland in the recent years lead to an increase in the creation of employment. In 2016, there was 4.1% of the total Poland labor market working directly or indirectly in tourism industries (Eurostat 2019).

In 2019 July, Poland government launched a new social package that includes a range of benefits to residents, such as the abolition of income tax for workers under 26 years old, an additional 13th pension payment for pensioners once a year and even an extension of the Family 500 Plus programme for the first child. Therefore, Poles have a bigger disposable income and, so, more propensity to travel (Euromonitor International 2019),

In addition, the "Poland See More- Half Price Weekend" initiative and "Holidays in Poland" programme offers them a way of cutting in travel costs, encouraging Poles to travel more within their country (BMI Research 2016).

Poles' rising spending power leads to multiplier effect. All the money that is spent during their domestic trip stills remains in the country, creating more profits to businesses and economy growth to the country.

7.1. Investments and Developments

Thanks to Multiplier Effect, the money of inbound and domestic tourists is spread through other sectors, contributing to the investments and developments tourism support structures.

Poland is considered to be an ideal investment destination, and along with the expansion of air routes, the hotel market is rising too, especially in the main cities (BMI Research 2016).

In order to support tourism growth, Poland is seriously investing in regional infrastructures, including the Central Transportation Port construction, improvements in the Airport of Krakow and the expansion of road and rail infrastructures, especially between Warsaw and Lodz (Euromonitor International 2019).

The country has revised its environmental law to guarantee ecological protection and conservation (MarketLine 2018).

Poland tourism industries have been improving in lodging, promotional activities, where national and regional Tourism Organisations are involved, beneficial social initiatives to encourage residents to travel within their country and specially in extensive marketing and promotion campaigns to increase awareness of its tourist attractions. (Euromonitor International 2019).

In the recent years, it is been done large investments in cultural events such as the World Youth Day, the Film Music Festival, Poland Fashion Week, the Festival of Jewish Culture and the Open'er Music Festival. Along with these, Poland has hosted the UEFA European Championship in 2012 and the 2019 FIFA World Cup U-20 (BMI Research 2016).

7.2. Trends

One of the rising tourism markets in Poland is business trips, especially in Warsaw capital. The number of business travels is highly increasing and some investments in business infrastructure have been made in the city, as well as the creation of new business travellers hotels (ABTA Magazine 2019).

For the 1st time, Krakow was won the European Capital of Gastronomic Culture 2019 title, attracting thousands of cultural food lovers. Award-winning restaurants, markets with local products and qualified regional food are providing to the rich culinary tradition of Krakow. Furthermore, the city offered a range of events to promote its art gastronomic, such as the Easter and Christmas fairs, the Molopolska Festival of Taste, the Bread Festival, The Pierogi Festival and some more (Poland.pl 2019).

As a destination, Poland is also very known for being a weekend (or extended) city-break market segment. Poles prefer to travel more often in their country, but for short periods of time. Regarding it, mostly of them opt for choosing All-Inclusive options, preferring to pay more to have better quality facilities (Ministry of Sport and Tourism of Republic of Poland 2017).

8. Impacts of Tourism in Poland

Although, Tourism is an important activity that brings wealth, economic benefits and job creation, there are some detrimental consequences in some nations or cities.

How receiving many visitors, the host' destination can face some cultural, social and even environmental impacts that are not very beneficial. It depends not just in the numbers of visitors a city attracts but also on the types of them (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 136).

It is very common to happen a lack of understanding of cultural and social traditions of the host destination. Phenomenon's like overcrowding, mass tourism and tourist misbehaving contribute to an increase of criminal activity, loss of identity and environmental issues (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 137).

As Dixey (1975) stated, the Irridex Model analyses the stress in relation to tourism development stages (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 135), as presented in Figure 2.

In the case of Poland, most visitors do not experience huge difficulties and the impacts are not so notable, remaining to be between Euphoria and Apathy (Stage 1 and Stage 2). The most problematic city is Krakow, with a growing and unchecked mass tourism phenomenon, possibly assessed in Stage 3, Irritation.

Stages	Characteristics	Symptoms
Stage 1	Euphoria	Visitors welcomed, little formal development
Stage 2	Apathy	Visitors taken for granted, contacts become commercial
Stage 3	Irritation	Locals concerned about tourism, efforts made to improve infrastructure
Stage 4	Antagonism	Open hostility from locals, attempts to limit damage and tourism flows

Figure 2. Irridex model of stress (Holloway and Humphreys 2016: 135)

However, foreigners may look as lucrative targets, and happenings like street crime (pickpockets or bag snatchers), robbery in rail stations (mainly in overnight trains) and overcharging taxi drivers, bars and nightclubs are probably to occur (Dorsi 2017).

9. Conclusion

Through this report's research, it is possible to conclude that Poland has a lot of potential as a tourism destination. The country is benefiting from a great location and rich resources that are attracting tourists every day.

In the case Poland continues improving their infrastructures, updating tourism support amenities and investing in marketing and promotional campaigns, the country will certainly keep up with tourism growth.

However, there is a need to progress and create new activities to tourists and not just in the current main cities, otherwise will cause the growth of mass tourism.

Overall, Poland is in the right direction and it has all the tools to remain addressing the latest trends in the industry and increase the contribution to its economy.

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